

Boulanger — Deep Research Report

Prepared for: Chief Technology Officer and technology leadership

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Where this document is thin

1. Company at a glance

Boulanger is France's leading specialist retailer of household appliances and consumer electronics, founded in 1954 and headquartered at Lesquin, near Lille. It sits inside United.b, the holding that also owns Electro Dépôt, Krëfel and Hifi International, along with the refurbishment businesses Recommerce and Reconomia. United.b is 88% owned by the Association Familiale Mulliez, with the remaining 12% held by employee shareholders — an ownership structure that shapes how investment decisions get made and how long a payback horizon the business will accept.

Trade press put Boulanger's revenue at around €4.35 billion in 2023 and €4.74 billion in 2024, against a technical goods market that has been contracting. Émilie Soleri, who became managing director in summer 2023, told République Retail in October 2025 that the company continues to take market share despite the downturn. The network stood at 223 stores in France in autumn 2025, around fifty of them franchised, and 221 with 53 franchises by mid-2026. Headcount is roughly 9,000 to 10,000 in France.

Two structural shifts matter for anyone planning systems work. First, the franchise mix is changing fast: Boulanger is targeting roughly ten openings a year toward 250 stores by 2027, and appointed Aurélien Châtelet in March 2026 to lead franchise development with a team of 35, aiming for 100 franchised stores by 2030 against 53 today. Second, store formats have diversified — large out-of-town units, urban concepts, corners and service points — including a Montparnasse store where Boulanger shares a floor with Decathlon City. Both trends push more variation into every rollout.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What proportion of the estate will be franchised in three years, and what does that change about how systems are deployed and supported?
- How much of the technology function is shared across United.b brands versus owned by Boulanger alone?
- Are the different store formats running the same stack, or has each picked up its own variations?

2. Strategic direction

The clearest strategic statement is the shift from selling products to selling solutions. Soleri put it plainly in October 2025: the one-shot product sale is no longer the engine, and a customer buying a new item should find an ecosystem of services around it. This is not aspiration — roughly a third of the workforce now sits in repair, installation, delivery or technical assistance, and the Club Infinity subscription for maintaining and repairing products has passed 500,000 customers, which

Boulanger intends to double. Subscribers report a Net Promoter Score ten to twenty points above other customers.

Digital is the second pillar and it is performing. Online now represents close to 30% of revenue and passed the billion-euro mark in 2025, growth that Soleri described as running at three times the market rate. The website and mobile app were rebuilt in October 2025 alongside the "Plaisir partagé" brand platform, with the app positioned as the central entry point to the customer relationship and a stated ambition to double the roughly 10% of revenue it currently generates. The marketplace, launched in 2016, remains a small share of online sales and is undergoing a full strategy rebuild.

Circularity is tracked as a business metric rather than a communications theme. Boulanger created an internal indicator, sustainable revenue, aggregating products and services with positive environmental impact; it stands at 25% of revenue against 19% two years earlier and reaches one sale in two in some categories. The company describes itself as France's largest collector of waste electrical and electronic equipment and has tripled buy-back volumes in two years. Own brands were cut from six to three — Listo, Essentiel B and the gaming brand Skillkorp — and are growing at double-digit rates.

Retail media is the newest revenue line. Boulanger and Auchan have handed retail media monetisation, online and offline, to Valiuz Adz. In-store digital screens are being deployed to 75 stores by the end of 2026, with 50 live before June; those 50 were selected for high traffic and television sales and represent an audience of 18.6 million customers a year. A test at the Englos store near Lille across 15 advertisers produced an average 15% uplift in those brands' revenue, and 72% of 300 surveyed shoppers said the screens improved the in-store experience.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Doubling the app's revenue contribution — what has to change technically for that to happen?
- What does the marketplace rebuild involve, and is it a platform decision or a commercial one?
- How is the sustainable revenue indicator actually computed, and which systems feed it?

3. Industry forces

The French technical goods market has been in decline since the post-pandemic equipment surge unwound, which is why Boulanger's growth is being described as share capture rather than market recovery. That distinction matters: in a shrinking market, cost discipline is permanent and every technology investment has to argue for itself against store investment, which Soleri says runs to several tens of millions of euros a year.

Competitive pressure is arriving from unfamiliar directions. Alongside Fnac Darty and Electro Dépôt, Boulanger now faces the Chinese group JD.com entering the French market and Back Market — previously a pure refurbished-goods platform — opening its own physical stores. The boundary between marketplace, refurbisher and physical retailer is dissolving, and the services and circularity strategy is partly a response to that.

Services and circularity are becoming the industry's shared answer. Fnac Darty has made the same bet, targeting close to four million subscribers by 2030. This converges the sector on a common technical problem: subscription and repair businesses require end-to-end process reliability in a way product sales do not. As Soleri put it, when a customer pays monthly for a service, the whole journey has to be faultless. That is a systems requirement before it is a service one.

AI has moved into production across the sector during 2025 and 2026, and the deployments that matter are internal-facing as much as customer-facing. The competitive question is no longer whether to adopt but whether a retailer's data foundations let it move quickly.

Questions to ask on the day:

- How does JD.com's arrival and Back Market's move into stores change your priorities, if at all?
- What breaks first when a subscription business scales — the process, the data, or the integration?

4. Regulatory and compliance frame

The most immediate regulatory change is already live. The EU Right to Repair Directive, Directive (EU) 2024/1799, became applicable on 31 July 2026, the deadline by which all member states had to transpose it. It obliges producers to repair covered products — including washing machines, refrigerators, vacuum cleaners, electronic displays, mobile phones and tablets — at reasonable price and within reasonable time, including outside the legal guarantee. Where a consumer chooses repair over replacement within the statutory warranty, the liability period is extended once by twelve months. Because it is a directive rather than a regulation, the products and obligations are harmonised but penalties are set separately in each national law; Germany, often cited as ahead of schedule, only passed its implementing *Reparaturgesetz* on 26 June 2026. A European online repair platform interface is due from the Commission by 31 July 2027, becoming fully operational on 1 January 2028.

For Boulanger this is closer to an operational advantage than a threat, given the existing repair network and Club Infinity. But it turns repair into a tracked legal obligation with timing, pricing and warranty-extension consequences that have to be captured in systems rather than managed by service teams informally. The twelve-month extension in particular has to be recorded against

individual products and honoured years later.

On environmental compliance, WEEE obligations require Boulanger to accept customers' old equipment and to fund collection and recycling through producer responsibility schemes; the company positions itself as France's leading WEEE collector, and appears as a party alongside the eco-organisme ecosystem in commercial litigation during 2025. France's AGECL law layers on further duties around unsold goods, eco-contributions and product information labelling. These generate reporting data that has to come from somewhere reliable.

Data protection is not theoretical here. On the night of 6 to 7 September 2024 Boulanger suffered a cyberattack affecting customer information linked to deliveries. The company stated no bank details were involved and that the incident was contained; press reporting indicated names, addresses, postcodes, phone numbers and email addresses were exposed, with a database offered on the dark web, and put the number of affected customers in the hundreds of thousands. Trade press criticised the customer notification for omitting guidance on risks and mitigation and for not providing data protection officer contact details, as Article 34 of the GDPR requires. The CNIL's 2024 annual report listed Boulanger among the year's large-scale breach victims, in a year when incidents affecting more than a million people doubled. Separately, the CNIL issued Boulanger a formal notice in 2015 over abusive customer comments stored in its database.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What did the September 2024 incident change about how security is resourced and governed?
- How is the Right to Repair twelve-month warranty extension recorded and honoured across systems?
- Which compliance reporting still depends on manual extraction?

5. The technology leader's world at Boulanger

Boulanger's IT function is described publicly as a group of around 300 specialists working on what the company calls a modern, agile stack. Alongside it sits a Data and AI directorate created as a distinct function. Marie Cappelaere holds the role of Chief Data & AI Officer for both Boulanger and United.b, which means AI and data strategy is set across the group's brands rather than for Boulanger alone.

The most instructive recent decision is a build-versus-buy policy, and it was forced by demand rather than chosen at leisure. Cappelaere described the situation at the Connect Lille forum in November 2025: more and more internal business functions wanted to use AI in their daily work, and each was being approached by external vendors offering their own specialised agent. Rather than let that proliferate, the team set an explicit rule — buy the universal technology components,

build in-house wherever Boulanger has genuine domain expertise. The team then built a technical platform and a methodology so that new specialised agents could be created quickly.

The first use case was deliberately chosen from the company's strongest ground: after-sales service, where Boulanger repairs products in customers' homes and holds capability that pure online players do not. The first agent went live at the end of September 2025 after a four-month build, integrated into the mobile app. Several more followed — an FAQ agent, one covering order, case and repair status, and one giving store opening hours and footfall — coordinated by an orchestrator agent that routes each question to the right capability. Because the agents are wired into Boulanger's existing customer data, responses draw on who the customer is and what they have bought.

The delivery model is worth noting. Cappelaere was explicit that Boulanger relies primarily on internal capability, calling in outside experts for specific needs but keeping no permanent consulting firm, with framing workshops run alongside technology partners including Microsoft. The stated motivation is control of the value chain and of the data. Feedback loops combine customer conversations and input from customer service staff, who use the agent themselves and act as expert reviewers of its answers.

Measurement is the honest gap. Early indicators show the after-sales agent is the most used and generates a high volume of automatically created cases, and the team tracks contact volumes, request types and call durations. Customer satisfaction and Net Promoter Score comparisons against the classic journey are stated as intentions rather than results. Boulanger handles around six million customer requests a year with 500 dedicated customer relations staff, so the denominator is large enough for the measurement question to matter commercially.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Where has the build-versus-buy line actually landed, and has it held under pressure from the business?
- What does the agent platform look like underneath, and what would it take to extend it to store-facing use cases?
- Which metrics will decide whether the agent programme continues, and who owns them?
- How much of the 300-strong IT function is on new development versus keeping existing systems running?

6. Peer signals

Fnac Darty is the closest comparison and has been explicit about the money. Its Beyond Everyday plan, unveiled in June 2025, raises annual capital expenditure to €200 million from €160 million,

with roughly half earmarked for technology transformation — modernising IT systems and integrating AI. The group reported 2025 revenue of €10.33 billion, up 0.7% on a comparable basis, with online sales up 5.8% at 22% of the total and click-and-collect close to half of web sales. It reached 2.4 million service subscribers against a 2030 target of four million, trained all employees on AI in 2024, and runs 30 internal technical academies producing 200 technicians a year. It is also currently subject to a takeover offer from EP Group, which has said it does not intend to change the strategy.

MediaMarktSaturn took the opposite architectural route to Boulanger on AI: partner-built rather than in-house. MyBuddy is a multi-language, real-time, voice-enabled agent worn in-ear by store associates, developed with Microsoft, Accenture and Avanade on Azure OpenAI, letting staff hold a conversation with a customer while querying product databases, support content and inventory in real time. The group has separately opened its in-store retail media inventory to programmatic booking through One Tech Group, with a phased rollout across European markets during 2026.

The contrast between those two is the useful frame for a conversation with Boulanger. MediaMarktSaturn bought speed and capability from partners and put the agent in the store, in the staff's ear. Boulanger built its own platform, kept the data in-house, and put the agent in the customer's app first. Neither is obviously right, and the interesting question is what each approach costs later.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Having built in-house, what would it take to extend the agent platform to store associates the way MediaMarktSaturn has?
- Fnac Darty is committing roughly €100 million a year to technology transformation. How does your investment envelope compare, and is it framed the same way?
- Retail media is being handled through Valiuz. What does that mean for who owns the data and the integration work?

7. Friction map

The evidence points to a technology function moving faster than its measurement can follow. A four-month build to a live customer-facing agent, followed by several more agents and an orchestrator, is genuine velocity. But the same account concedes that satisfaction and loyalty impact are not yet measured, and that the team is still learning what the tool is good for. Velocity without a settled measurement frame tends to produce a portfolio of initiatives that nobody can rank.

The second tension is demand management. The trigger for the build-versus-buy policy was that individual business functions were being courted directly by AI vendors. That policy resolves the

architecture question but not the queue: the appetite that produced the vendor approaches has not gone away, and every function that wanted its own agent still wants one. A platform that makes agents cheap to build makes that queue longer, not shorter.

Third, the estate is becoming more heterogeneous at the same time as the technology is becoming more centralised. Franchised stores are set to rise from 53 toward 100 by 2030, formats range from out-of-town units to shared-floor urban concepts, and the group spans four retail brands plus refurbishment businesses. Anything built centrally has to survive that variation.

Fourth, the service and subscription model raises the cost of any process failure. Half a million Club Infinity subscribers paying monthly, six million customer requests a year, and a legal repair obligation live since July 2026 mean that end-to-end reliability is now a commercial and regulatory exposure rather than a service-quality nicety.

Questions to ask on the day:

- How do you currently decide which AI use case goes next, and who makes that call?
- Where is the estate's heterogeneity costing you most — franchise, format, or brand?
- What is the single process whose failure would hurt most right now?

Challenge cards

Card 1 of 2

Title: The queue behind the platform

The challenge: Business functions across the company want AI in their daily work, and external vendors are approaching each of them directly with a specialised agent. Building a platform that makes new agents fast to create answers the architecture question but makes the demand question sharper, because the barrier to asking has dropped.

Who feels it: The technology and data leadership who must sequence the work, the business functions waiting their turn, and the teams whose shadow procurement gets blocked.

Why it persists: The demand is legitimate — each function has a real problem — and the vendor offers are credible. The internal platform is genuinely faster than it was, which raises expectations rather than lowering them. There is no obvious neutral basis for saying which use case goes first once several have plausible value.

What solved looks like: A stated, defensible sequencing rule that business functions understand and accept, tied to measurable value rather than to who asked loudest. The buy-versus-build line

stays stable under pressure instead of being renegotiated case by case.

Evidence base: Marie Cappelaere, Chief Data & AI Officer of Boulanger and United.b, described the origin of the policy at the Connect Lille forum in November 2025: growing internal demand, each function being approached by outside vendors, and the resulting decision to buy universal components and build where Boulanger's own expertise is the differentiator.

Open question: What is the current rule for choosing the next agent, and has it survived contact with a senior stakeholder who disagreed?

Card 2 of 2

Title: Proving the agent worked

The challenge: The conversational agent has been live since the end of September 2025 and is being used, but the measures that would show whether it improved anything for the customer are still being built. Contact volumes and call durations are tracked; satisfaction and loyalty comparisons against the classic journey are stated as intentions.

Who feels it: Technology and data leadership defending the investment, customer service managers whose workload it is meant to relieve, and whoever has to decide what gets funded next.

Why it persists: The build moved faster than the instrumentation. Comparing an AI-assisted journey to the classic one requires a clean control, consistent tagging across channels, and agreement on which outcome counts — deflected contacts, faster resolution, or a better experience. Those are different metrics that can move in opposite directions.

What solved looks like: A stable comparison between the assisted and unassisted journeys on satisfaction and Net Promoter Score as well as volume, so that the next round of investment rests on evidence rather than on enthusiasm and early feedback.

Evidence base: Cappelaere told République Retail in November 2025 that the after-sales agent is the most used and generates a high volume of automatically created cases, that the team follows contact volumes, request types and call durations, and that measuring customer satisfaction and Net Promoter Score against the classic journey is a future step. Boulanger handles around six million customer requests a year with 500 dedicated customer relations staff.

Open question: Which single number would you want to be able to show the executive committee in twelve months, and what is stopping you from producing it today?

Where this document is thin

- No named CTO, CIO or IT director for Boulanger appears in public sources; the technology function is described only by size.
- The IT budget, its split between run and change, and how it compares with store investment are not public.
- Boulanger's 2025 revenue figure has not been published; 2023 and 2024 figures come from trade press and vary slightly between sources.
- The chair of Boulanger's board changed in a 2025 registry filing and should be confirmed rather than taken from older summaries.
- Core platform detail — ERP, point of sale, e-commerce, order management, cloud provider — is not documented publicly beyond Microsoft appearing as an AI framing partner.
- The marketplace rebuild is confirmed as underway but nothing describes its scope, platform or timeline.
- How much of the technology estate is shared across United.b brands versus specific to Boulanger is unclear.
- No public information exists on how franchised stores are supported technically or what they run.
- The remediation following the September 2024 breach has not been described publicly, and no CNIL enforcement outcome against Boulanger has been reported.
- Whether the Right to Repair obligations have driven specific systems changes is unknown.
- Security headcount, tooling and governance arrangements are undocumented.